

With great power come greater threats!

ChatGPT just faced its first country-specific ban, with Italy temporarily banning ChatGPT over data protection and privacy concerns. The Italian Data Protection Authority is probing possible General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) violations connected to ChatGPT. This might just be the beginning of a parallel movement that calls for the setting up of guardrails and rules of engagement when it comes to AI models that extensively use and depend on user data.

A peek into ChatGPT's privacy policy reveals how it not only captures user data but is also free to share it with third parties without any further notice to you. There's no way to know exactly how user data will be used and shared, keeping all of us guessing. The privacy policy states: "In certain circumstances, we may provide your Personal Information to third parties without further notice to you, unless required by the law."

AI tools are built on data, and the more granular and detailed the data, the better will be their results. While mining user data isn't a new phenomenon, the advent of AI language models has ushered in a new era, where personal data can be stitched together to create compelling narratives, predict behaviors, and even generate alternate avatars. Unfortunately, we have already lost the privacy battle long ago, as most popular internet-enabled services rely on user data to thrive and survive. The use of AI tools is simply the next logical step in this progression. However, we must understand the potential implications of this new dimension of data sharing. With AI tools, we are leaping into a new era of data-driven decision-making that requires us to be aware of the risks and take appropriate steps to mitigate them.

While there may be no turning back from the path we have set out on, we must remain vigilant in our efforts to protect privacy and ensure that the use of AI language models is done responsibly and ethically. Only then can we truly harness the power of AI tools for the greater good. We need to ensure the positives and benefits far outshine the threats and downsides



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of feeding personal information to AI models. Right now, most of us have our blinders on, as we share the excitement around the power and potential of AI models. However, it's of paramount importance to be well aware of how our personal data is mined and ensure we have control over what is ok and what is a no-go.

Besides privacy, intellectual property (IP) violation is another major concern around generative AI models. These tools depend on content that is spread across millions of textbooks, newspapers and websites, across geographies. All of this is seemingly 'scraped' without consent and it raises a massive issue of copyright and IP infringement; unlike websites indexing or highlighting content from other sources, which can be traced, detected, and held accountable in a transparent manner. When it comes to AI models, it's a black box that processes information and content owned by individuals or corporations to generate an output that cannot be tracked back to its original sources. Early in 2023, Getty Images filed a lawsuit against Stability AI for copyright infringement, alleging that the company copied 12 million images to train its AI model without permission. So, who owns the content generated by AI models? And how is the original content owner compensated (or attributed) for it? Generative AI can infringe on copyrights and produce counterfeit products. It's crucial to use copyright laws, best practices, and licenses when training AI models.

Like any revolutionary tech, with all the excitement and euphoria comes the army of naysayers and skeptics, and for good measure. It's a necessary evil that keeps things in check. I don't belong to that army just yet. But the AI revolution is like no other I have witnessed ever and it has the potential to change how we live our digital lives and beyond forever. With that kind of great power coming our way, the need for responsibility and control is greater than ever.

What are your thoughts on AI? Are we just too paranoid for no reason? Or is there a need for a cautious and regulated approach? Write to me at soham@digit.in, I'd love to know your thoughts! 